

Somalia



A semiarid state occupying the Horn of Africa, Somalia was formed from the Italian and British colonies of Somaliland. Conflict has left it without effective government since 1991.



GEOGRAPHY

Highlands in the north, flatter scrub-covered land to the south. Coastal areas are more fertile.



CLIMATE

Very dry, except for the north coast, which is hot and humid. The interior has among the world's highest average annual temperatures.



PEOPLE & SOCIETY

The clan system forms the basis of all commercial, political, and social life. Most people are ethnic Somali. The minority Bantu are traditionally seen as socially inferior. Since the 1991 coup, Somalia has lacked a strong central authority. Somaliland has declared independence, while Puntland claims autonomy. Islamist militias now control most of the country: some have joined the latest attempt at a transitional government, but fighting continues.

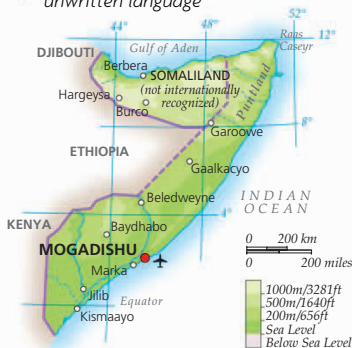


THE ECONOMY

Ongoing war. Every commodity, except arms, is in short supply. Piracy and banditry. Few natural resources. Prone to drought. Somaliland region is more stable, but its trade is hampered by lack of international recognition.



INSIGHT: Until 1973, Somali was an unwritten language



FACTFILE

OFFICIAL NAME: Somalia

DATE OF FORMATION: 1960

CAPITAL: Mogadishu

POPULATION: 9.13 million

TOTAL AREA: 246,199 sq. miles
(637,657 sq. km)

DENSITY: 38 people per sq. mile

LANGUAGES: Somali*, Arabic*, English, Italian

RELIGIONS: Sunni Muslim 98%, Christian 2%

ETHNIC MIX: Somali 85%, other 15%

GOVERNMENT: Transitional regime

CURRENCY: Somali shilin = 100 senti